

Geometry Dash

In my middle schools year, I had very restricted access to my phone and other gaming consoles. It left me with only one accessible game : Geometry Dash (Lite). Needless to say, I spent all my time on it.

Geometry Dash is a side-scrolling music platform game with 7 different levels (at its release) that range from low to high difficulty. In order to finish a level, you must stay alive, and to do so, you need to avoid all spikes and obstacles by touching the screen and making the square (that you control and personalise) jump. Essentially, **the only action you can do is to tap the screen**.

Every jump matches the music's beat. I become absorbed by the rhythm, tapping in sync with its pace. It becomes almost *unconscious*, I feel in trance with the music and forget my environment — until I die. I jumped too early, and collided into a spike. I hit restart.

Every time I restart the same 7 levels, whatever the difficulty, the sensation of muscle-memory grows a little sharper. I don't have to think about jumping, it becomes a *reflex*, my finger moves on its own. Little by little when getting to the harder levels, it's not about knowing the pattern of the level, but even knowing the weight, speed and momentum of my little personalised square idle. There is no room for hesitation : each small error is unforgiving and makes me restart the level **from the start**. So as I progress, I am no longer playing through reacting and jumping accordingly to the pattern of the next spike : instead, I am anticipating the future obstacles before they even appear on a screen. There is even a level I could entirely do with my eyes closed, just following the music and my memory.

The square is no longer a random shape that I make jump, it becomes an extension of my body, a sort of exoself of my body that I *play* with and not just *control* it. The more I play, the less I am mad for losing. It's more of a reminder that I'm becoming better and need training, a sort of ongoing mastery process, as I tend to be feeling extreme competitiveness when playing these kind of games. Turns out the idea of mastery died when I discovered other kind of games, and left Geometry Dash to the oblivion.

However, this training was definitely not for nothing : if anything, it was the start of my '**gamer habitus**'. Geometry Dash, Piano Tiles, Flappy Bird, all these mobiles games played during my childhood transformed into a set of skills applicable in other video games. It's become a form of embedded learning, that I feel vividly real in my fingertips, my breath, my focus. And whenever I launch a new video game, whether it be a JRPG or a FPS, my muscles remember all those hours spent training endlessly to reach a mastery that I never achieved. But in a sense, it went even beyond, as I will remember these skills for life for every other game.